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Breaking organizational paths for strategic renewal: Towards a dialectical perspective

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ABSTRACT

Strategic renewal is key to organizations' long-term success, but may be difficult to achieve if they are locked into a particular action path. Unfortunately, breaking organizational paths remains somewhat elusive due to a binary opposition in the strategic renewal literature between path breaking and path dependence, which hampers more complex process theorization. Asking what roles path breaking and path dependence exactly play in strategic renewal, we perform an in-depth case study of path-breaking interventions at fashion retailer Kiabi. This firm gradually moved from a path of disintegrative to integrative collaborative alignment between departments, whereby adaptive expectations regarding others' willingness to collaborate gradually improved. Chiefly, we find that strategic renewal is a function of two concurrent dialectics: 1) between path-breaking interventions and relapses into old path-dependent tendencies; and 2) between initiatives by upper management and their firm-wide implementation. We contribute to the literature by demonstrating that organizational path dependence, through managerial reflection and action, can be integral to path breaking, and, more broadly, strategic renewal. Furthermore, we extend common notions of managerial agency in path breaking by highlighting the involvement of various hierarchical layers, while, paradoxically, we relax the strong assumption of managerial agency that exists in studies on open strategy.

1. Introduction

Strategic renewal is gaining traction in scholarly debates because of its interest in the process, content, and outcome of refreshing or replacing those attributes of an organization that cause strategic inertia and may thus hurt long-term performance (Perini et al., 2024). In practice, one can observe how organizations are forced onto a path of strategic renewal by market and/or competitive dynamics, but then experience difficulties when implementing new action patterns. In a crucial subset of difficult cases, organizations do not just face strategic inertia, but locked-in organizational paths, marked by a self-reinforcing mechanism, in which a dominant action pattern has become fixed and therefore extremely difficult to dislodge (Sydow et al., 2009; Vergne and Durand, 2010). Organizations attempting strategic renewal then have to resort to path-breaking interventions, which interrupt or alter limiting self-reinforcing processes (Koch, 2011).

Since the strategic renewal/inertia and path breaking/dependence research programs have both departed from an evolutionary perspective and share a focus on 1) the effects of prior events on an organization's strategic trajectory, and 2) the ways firmsm generate

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alternative courses of action (Flier et al., 2003), one would expect and tight relationship between forces of change and stability in strategic renewal. However, the literature tends to create a limiting binary opposition between those two forces (Nguyen et al., 2022), generally treating organizations as unified actors that move in one or the other strategic direction (Su et al., 2023; Koch, 2011; Stache and Sydow, 2023), so that one force necessarily takes precedence over the other (Farjoun, 2010). Furthermore, although path breaking and path dependence have been discussed with reference to strategic renewal and inertia (e.g., De Groote and Kammerlander, 2023; Löfsten et al., 2024; Zientara and Müller-Seitz, 2024), how managers maneuver path breaking and path dependence for the purpose of strategic renewal remains elusive. Conversely, research on strategic inertia and renewal has paid hardly more than lip service to path dependence and path breaking (e.g., Volberda et al., 2001; Schmitt et al., 2018; Friesl et al., 2019). There is, therefore, little systematic knowledge about the way(s) in which organizations escape particular instances of strategic inertia that involve counterproductive locked-in action paths (Schmitt et al., 2018; Perini et al., 2024). Therefore, we ask: *How can management maneuver self-reinforcing mechanisms when breaking an organizational path for strategic renewal?*

Further investigating the role of self-reinforcing mechanisms could lead to a more granular understanding of what drives successful renewal in light of strategic inertia, specifically in regard to the intricate dynamics of stability and change that also seem central to understanding "the intricacy of path-breaking interventions" (Keller et al., 2023: 15). In particular, we find that the testing, deploying, and assimilating of path-breaking interventions—all aimed at strategic renewal—are, at least to some extent, anchored in path dependence and the self-reinforcing mechanism underlying it. We will outline how breaking organizational path dependence hinges on both forces of stability and change—not only sequentially, but also simultaneously—to ensure the survival and prosperity of organizations. In other words, to achieve strategic renewal and escape path dependence, organizations must not only overcome various periods of stability and change, but also skillfully maneuver the interplay between the two.

We identify three main benefits of connecting the path breaking/dependence and strategic renewal/inertia theoretical perspectives. First, a comprehensive view of path breaking and path dependence highlights self-reinforcement as a dimension of strategic renewal. As such, it may have the capacity to not just unveil how action paths get locked in, but also how to escape them. At times, counterintuitively, self-reinforcement may eventually help to break free from organizational path dependence (cf., Stache and Sydow, 2023). Thereby, it provides a more nuanced stance on the tension between stability and change in strategic renewal processes that deal with structural inertia (Hannan and Freeman, 1984; Perini et al., 2024), going well beyond a binary and sequential understanding (Farjoun, 2010). Second, a path breaking/dependence approach challenges functional or fit-based models that focus on adaptive processes. While many strategic renewal studies show how exogenous shocks lead to renewal within organizations (e.g., Karim and Mitchell, 2000; Pratap and Saha, 2018), they generally do not explain how organizational paths are broken from within, and how this might even lead to organizations influencing their external environments. Finally, insofar the broader organization is involved in shaping a new strategic focus, the emphasis on self-reinforcing mechanisms in strategic renewal relaxes the common assumption of strong managerial agency in the opening and closing of strategy-making (Dobusch et al., 2019; Splitter et al., 2023; Diriker et al., 2023). That is, even if managers can mobilize the broader organization in maneuvering self-reinforcing mechanisms, the very presence of these mechanisms introduces an element of unintentionality and emergence.

The rest of our paper is structured as follows. First, we examine the extant literature on strategic renewal and inertia with a special focus on the duality of path breaking and path dependence. Second, we present our research context—French fashion retailer Kiabi—, the methodology we used, and the results of our empirical fieldwork, which consisted of reconstructing and trailing Kiabi's path-breaking efforts between 2010 and 2020. Our findings mainly reveal the working of two related dialectics in this transition: one between the forces of path breaking and path dependence, and another between the actions of upper management and the firm at large. We then describe the three theoretical contributions that flow from our theorization of path-breaking intervention as a dialectical process. First, it offers a more nuanced, granular view of strategic renewal that moves beyond binary oppositions of stability and change, and integrates path breaking and path dependence in a singular process. Second, as it demonstrates the broad involvement of organizational actors across departments and hierarchical layers, it deepens the image of what managerial agency looks like if confronted with organizational path dependence. Third, paradoxically, it places the practice of open strategy in a context of potentially constraining structures, thus attenuating the dominant view that organizations deliberately move between strategic openness and closure. We conclude by outlining practical implications and suggestions for future research.

1.1. Theoretical background

Strategic renewal is often understood as a form of organizational change that pertains to the process, content, and outcome of refreshing or even replacing central attributes to an organization. As such, it bears the potential to substantially affect an organization's long-term prospects in light of observed or anticipated changes (Agarwal and Helfat, 2009)—hence, the prefix "strategic". Meanwhile, *strategic inertia* is usually understood as an organization's inability to adapt its strategy and structure in light of changes having taken place or anticipated in the competitive environment, and can threaten an organization's economic survival and prosperity (Helfat, 2022; Huff et al., 1992). Inertia can result from various conditions, including distorted perception (e.g., blind spots due to hubris or misled by planning and control systems), dulled motivation (e.g., because of high sunk costs), insufficient responsiveness (e.g., due to a lack of strategic vision), political deadlock (e.g., because of competing department interests), or action disconnects (e.g., due to embedded routines).

In some cases, strategic inertia involves organizational *path dependence*—with its self-reinforcing processes that produce lock-in. By lock-in, we refer to a stage where a dominant action pattern has become fixed and is extremely difficult to unlock within reasonable cost parameters (Sydow et al., 2009; Koch, 2011; Vergne and Durand, 2010). At least four self-reinforcing mechanisms have the potential to create such positive feedbacks (Sydow et al., 2009; Koch, 2011). First, *coordination* effects emerge when more actors follow the same rule, which makes it more difficult to change the rule. Second, *complementarity* effects emerge when different rules and/or resources fit nicely together. Third, *learning* effects result from repetition. Finally, *adaptive expectation* effects relate to the interactive building of preferences and arise from the expectation that a certain behavioral or operational standard (with respect to rules and/or resources) will prevail. This process of an ever-narrowing scope of choice is likely to lead to lock-in, in which the path is hard, if not impossible, to escape. Though not an inherently bad force, organizational path dependence, for which one self-reinforcing mechanism may suffice (Sydow et al., 2020), can become strategically problematic if external circumstances call for organizational change or strategic renewal efforts that an organization is unable to deliver (Agarwal and Helfat, 2009). Fig. 1 visualizes the conceptual relationship between strategic inertia and path dependence, whereby the latter is a possible, though not necessary, condition of the former.

Relatedly, one influential working definition of strategic renewal evokes the notion of *path breaking*: "strategic renewal is the process that allows organizations to alter their path dependence by transforming their strategic intent and capabilities" (Schmitt et al., 2018: 85). The notion of path breaking describes how organizations can escape path-dependent situations (e.g., De Groote and Kammerlander, 2023; Fortwengel and Keller, 2020; Keller et al., 2023; Stache and Sydow, 2023). According to received theory, they do so by not only creating new action patterns via "mindful deviation" and "disembedding" from prevailing structures (Garud and Karnøe, 2001; Garud et al., 2010), but also by effectively stopping or modifying extant self-reinforcing mechanisms underlying organizational path dependence (Fortwengel and Keller, 2020; Sydow et al., 2020). Such path breaking can be considered a specific form of strategic renewal that targets the way in which self-reinforcing mechanisms impact organizational or strategic trajectories—see Fig. 1 for a visual representation. Breaking *coordination* effects, for instance, may require organizational members to reorganize by establishing new strategic missions and/or organizational rules. Altering *complementarity* effects may imply waiving existing synergies—at least for the time being—and becoming open to new alternatives. When *learning* effects result from effectively repeating activities, path breaking may require "unlearning" (Nystrom and Starbuck, 1984) prior to experimenting with new activities. Finally, *adaptive expectation* effects are likely to change when employees start questioning taken-for-granted beliefs and following new, organizationally favored goals or norms.

Research on strategic renewal has highlighted the process by which established firms escape particularly difficult situations, such as competitive rivalry (e.g., Huygens et al., 2001), market saturation (e.g., Kim and Pennings, 2009), or technological disruption (e.g., Knott and Posen, 2009). Yet, breaking an organizational path is often, though but not always, necessary to realize strategic renewal. If path dependence is "a rigidified, potentially inefficient action pattern built up by the unintended consequences of former decisions and positive feedback processes" (Sydow et al., 2009: 696), path breaking, in turn, would require (patterns of) action to interrupt or alter such a situation (represented by the dotted inner circle of Fig. 1). The fostering or alteration of self-reinforcing mechanisms involve repeated reflective action patterns and/or practices (Giddens, 1984; Jarzabkowski, 2008; Jarzabkowski and Spee, 2009). Bækkelund (2021), for example, focuses on path development in the Norwegian tourism industry, stating that not only "reproductive agency" but also "change agency", or "the ability to act at critical junctures" (760). Moreover, Fortwengel and Keller (2020) analyze how two established firms were able to regain scope of action by engaging with self-reinforcing mechanisms. While one leveraged an external shock in the form of a new strategic investor to instigate change, the other drew on structure to provide the necessary reflexivity to imagine an alternative future. Likewise, De Groote and Kammerlander's (2023) study of family firms yields that changes in power structures allow for a reevaluation of resources.

Although all these studies provide meticulous accounts of path breaking, this line of research still tends to create a binary opposition between stability and change, arguably due to the field's orientation towards dualisms (Giddens, 1984; Farjoun, 2010). Moreover, most research mobilizing a path-breaking lens has either considered the organization a single unified actor or focused on the cadre of managers (Su et al., 2023). This problem also marks the broader literature on strategic renewal and inertia that recognizes the importance of path dependence if not path breaking for these processes (cf., Lamberg et al., 2008; Koch, 2011; Stache and Sydow, 2023; Vergne and Durand, 2010, 2011). As noted by Nguyen et al. (2022: 1-1): "an underlying assumption in proactive renewal is that

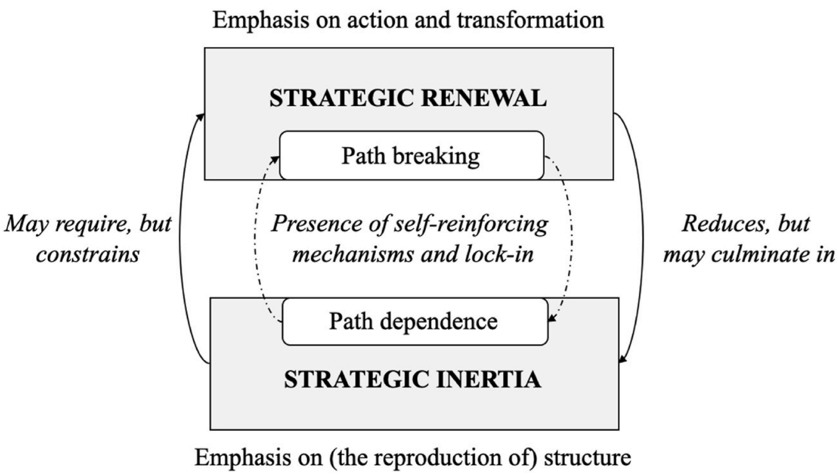

Fig. 1. Strategic renewal/inertia vs. path breaking/dependence.

some firms possess the capabilities to overcome their inertia to renew and actively fulfil their objectives." In effect, the strategic renewal literature tends to *evoke* the issue of organizational path dependence, but does not systematically *theorize* it. To illustrate, Huff et al. (1992), underline the tension between cumulative inertia (the commitment to current strategy) and organizational stress (the dissatisfaction that signals the need for renewal). Moreover, Flier et al. (2003) examine firms' engagement in strategic renewal by committing to past strategic choices whilst developing new capabilities. Likewise, Perini et al. (2024) identify strategic inertia and strategic renewal as two alternative, logically contrasting responses to similar competitive pressures. Some studies in this stream, such as Friesl et al. (2019), Schmitt et al. (2018), and Volberda et al. (2001), mention path dependence explicitly, but the term remains peripheral to their understanding of strategic renewal.

Thus, research is yet to seriously embrace a path-dependence/-breaking lens to accommodate the inherent complexity of strategic renewal. This lacuna is surprising, given not only the common departure of both streams of theorizing from an evolutionary perspective, but also the joint prevalence of discussions about path breaking and path dependence in the strategic renewal literature (e.g., Helfat, 2022; Schmitt et al., 2018). As a consequence, it remains unclear which activities are deployed—and how—to reproduce, alter, or stop self-reinforcing mechanisms with the aim of promoting strategic renewal within and across an organization. Research on strategic renewal could therefore benefit from a more explicit, theoretically informed focus on the interplay between path breaking and path dependence, allowing their underlying self-reinforcing mechanisms to occur simultaneously rather than sequentially producing both stability and change.

Against this backdrop, we set out to adopt a more dialectical view on strategic renewal (Farjoun and Fiss, 2021; Sminia, 2009), which allows for the maintenance of conceptual distinctions without necessarily committing to "rigid antagonism and separation" (Farjoun, 2010: 204). The resulting view of stability and change foregrounds a state of disequilibrium, where stability and change can flow into each other as part of one and the same organizational transformation process. Such a perspective, which foregrounds stability in change processes and changes in processes of stabilization, may thus offer a more nuanced account of strategic renewal, not least under the adverse circumstances of organizational path dependence.

1.2. Research context

Studying path breaking appears particularly suitable to contexts of high industrial turbulence, such as the semiconductor or retail industries (Sydow et al., 2012). In these industries, periods of relative stability are often alternated by episodes of significant change—around such alternations, when previously successful but possibly rigid structures (e.g., beliefs, understandings, values) need to be updated, path-breaking activities are more likely to occur and thus to become observable. For this reason, we conducted a four-year, in-depth case study at French ready-to-wear fashion retailer Kiabi (May 2016 to May 2020). Founded in 1978, Kiabi is now an 11,000-employee multinational, primarily located in France, Spain, Italy, and Russia. It offers affordable apparel for the whole family, and its closest competitors in 2025 are H&M and Primark. What makes Kiabi particularly suitable for studying the breaking of an organizational path is that in 2010, its upper management decided to embark on a journey of strategic renewal. Before, the firm's strategic position was eroding due to its collections having become outdated (Athané, 2017) and the arrival in France of Primark, another popular fast-fashion retailer, which was poised to intensify Kiabi's competitive environment.

To address this issue, incoming Chairman Edgard Bonte, who replaced the firm's founder, Patrick Mulliez, in 2011, decided to assess with the firm's CEO and other senior managers what problems were affecting Kiabi's competitive position. He came to realize that the firm's central problems were the prevalence of siloed work and the absence of strategic coordination. Indeed, executives agreed that cross-departmental collaboration was particularly lacking and that this issue needed to be resolved if the firm was to find a fruitful way forward:

> We deserve to operate with more trust, more respect, without looking over each other's shoulders, and therefore break down all these silos, break down these walls, and work much more on what unites us, rather than what separates us
>
> —Kiabi's CEO (2007–2014)
>
> (Toscane & Cie, 2015: 12:53–13:09).

However, pursuing this desire was going to be easier said than done. The problem of silos and lacking strategic direction had proven quite consistent over the years and was deeply inscribed in the firm's culture, because each manager was empowered to lead his business with full independence. This structural arrangement was characteristic of the entrepreneurial mindset of the Mulliez family (Blondé, 2015) and was engrained in Kiabi's remuneration scheme, which, as an ongoing survey shows, has for long featured profit-sharing bonuses (Distrijob, 2025). As such, Kiabi was locked in an organizational path driven by low adaptive expectations (cf., Sydow et al., 2009, 2020) regarding cross-departmental collaboration—employees were broadly expected to act as intrapreneurs. On this path of *disintegrative collaborative alignment*, no one took the initiative to collaborate. Strong managerial autonomy thus prevented the formulation of coordinated strategic choices, and perpetuated a pattern of "muddling through".

In light of these insights, upper management decided to mobilize principles of open strategy, such as transparency and inclusion (cf., Whittington et al., 2011; Hautz et al., 2017), and invited all employees to voice their opinion about the new strategic direction that the firm should take. From then on, employees were actively involved in breaking through the old siloed pattern and in moving Kiabi from a model based on basic, low-cost apparel to one with higher fashion standards, thus ensuring the firm's long-term prosperity. In the process, two practices were particularly relied upon: cross-departmental collaboration and agile methods, which refers to a suite of practices geared towards fast innovation (Rigby et al., 2016). Regarding collaboration, upper management was less concerned with influencing the outcome of the strategic content than with shaping the strategy-making process itself, reflecting what Dobusch (2019) labels “procedural openness”. More specifically, collaboration was used to empower employees to break the firm’s original path by formulating new strategic principles. As for agile methods, these served to solve emerging issues that were arising from the practice of collaboration.

2. Data and methods

The purpose of this study is to explore the dialectical relationship of path dependence and path breaking in processes of strategic renewal. To that aim, we conducted an in-depth case study (Yin, 2003) of Kiabi’s path-breaking journey, which took place between 2010 and 2020. In the process, we drew on four strands of qualitative data. First and foremost, we conducted a series of 48 *semi-structured interviews* (yielding a total of 49 h and 15 min of audio recording) between May 2016 and May 2020, capturing the crucial phase in which Kiabi’s path was effectively broken. Furthermore, we strived to cover various management layers and divisions, thus obtaining a broad perspective of the firm’s path-breaking dynamics which involved various different vantage points. Our interviewees were fairly equally distributed across layers: upper management [Chairman, CEO and Senior Vice-presidents] (17 %), senior managers [Chairman, CEO and Senior Vice-presidents] (33 %), middle managers with subordinates [Vice-presidents and Directors] (27 %), junior managers (21 %) and external consultant (2 %). Seven respondents were interviewed twice for clarification purposes. Interviewees were selected though snowballing (cf., Aguinis and Solarino, 2019), because it allowed us to access a network of

Table 1
List of interviews (chronological order).

I#	Interviewee’s role	Department	Mgt. level (rank)	Interview date	Interview duration	Interview modality
1	Project Manager, Collections	Projects team	Middle (3)	Dec 05, 2017	1:35:00	F2F
2	Leader Value Chain (EVP)	Executive committee	Upper (1)	Dec 13, 2017	59:07	F2F
3	Project Leader	Projects team	Middle (3)	14 Dec 2017	1:01:00	F2F
4	Project Leader	Projects team	Middle (3)	14 Dec 2017	1:19:00	F2F
5	Logistics manager	Supply Chain	Junior (4)	14 Dec 2017	1:10:23	F2F
6	Software architect	IT	Junior (4)	15 Dec 2017	57:45	F2F
7	Data Scientist	Marketing	Middle (3)	18 Dec 2017	1:04:56	F2F
8	Product manager, Lingerie	Collections	Junior (4)	12 Jan 2018	1:06:10	F2F
9	Project Leader	Projects team	Junior (4)	12 Jan 2018	1:04:09	F2F
10	Purchasing, non-marketable goods	Supply Chain	Senior (2)	16 Jan 2018	1:02:24	F2F
11	Digital Experience Marketing Leader	Marketing	Senior (2)	16 Jan 2018	43:19	F2F
12	Marketing Research & Studies Manager	Marketing	Junior (4)	16 Jan 2018	1:04:21	F2F
13	Manager Underwear, Collections	Collections	Junior (4)	16 Jan 2018	49:18	F2F
14	Leader, Collections Project team	Projects team	Junior (4)	17 Jan 2018	1:02:54	F2F
15	CSR Leader	RSE	Senior (2)	17 Jan 2018	56:46	F2F
16	Leader Trends Lab Collections	Collections	Middle (3)	17 Jan 2019	50:58	F2F
17	Leader RH World (VP)	Executive committee	Upper (1)	24 Jan 2018	47:31	F2F
18	Leader Merchandising France	Merchandising	Senior (2)	29 Jan 2018	51:37	F2F
19	International Development Project leader	Projects team	Middle (3)	15 Feb 2018	46:00	F2F
20	IT Governance Leader	IT	Senior (2)	16 Feb 2018	1:08:49	F2F
21	Internal Communication	HR	Senior (2)	16 Feb 2018	51:44	F2F
22	General Services Leader	Projects team	Middle (3)	16 Feb 2018	52:35	F2F
23	Leader Marketing	Executive committee	Upper (1)	21 Feb 2018	1:33:30	F2F
24	Project leader	Projects team	Middle (3)	23 Feb 2018	56:26	F2F
25	Change Management Leader	RH	Middle (3)	28 Feb 2018	45:15	F2F
26	E-marketing Director	Marketing	Senior (2)	28 Feb 2018	57:59	F2F
27	Store Manager	Stores	First-level (5)	07 Mar 2018	59:04	F2F
28	Leader Web	Marketing	Senior (2)	16 Mar 2018	50:01	F2F
29	CEO	Executive committee	Upper (1)	19 Mar 2018	56:24	F2F
30	Leader Supply Chain	Supply Chain	Senior (2)	09 Apr 2018	1:16:55	F2F
31	Leader “Shopping into the future”	Executive committee	Upper (1)	02 May 2018	49:33	F2F
32	Happiness and Empowerment Leader	HR	Senior (2)	02 May 2018	1:06:00	F2F
33	Leader, International Development (VP)	Executive committee	Upper (1)	04 May 2018	52:62	Call
34	Chairman	Executive committee	Upper (1)	14 May 2018	52:57	F2F
35	Consultant, Design Thinking	External	External (N/A)	15 May 2018	1:05:36	F2F
36	Project Manager, Collections	Projects team	Middle (3)	21 Sep 2018	1:15:10	F2F
37	Happiness and Empowerment Leader (2nd)	HR	Senior (2)	24 Sep 2018	1:03:43	F2F
38	Industrial engineer	Projects team	Middle (3)	25 Sep 2018	45:21	F2F
39	Project Manager Collections (2nd)	Projects team	Middle (3)	25 Sep 2018	1:02:32	F2F
40	Leader, Supply Chain (2nd)	Supply Chain	Senior (2)	25 Sep 2018	51:18	F2F
41	Style coordinator	Collections	Junior (4)	26 Sep 2018	41:37	F2F
42	Leader Value Chain (2nd)	Projects team	Senior (2)	11 Oct 2018	1:01:12	F2F
43	Raw Material Leader (purchasing)	Supply Chain	Senior (2)	18 Oct 2018	1:29:28	F2F
44	Project Leader, Projects team (2nd)	Projects team	Junior (4)	Oct 25, 2018	1:06:36	F2F
45	CEO (2nd)	Executive team	Upper (1)	Jan 22, 2019	1:09:41	F2F
46	Head of Projects	Projects team	Senior (2)	02 Apr 2019	01:36:41	F2F
47	Executive assistant	Executive team	Junior (4)	08 Apr 2019	1:13:26	F2F
48	Communication Leader (2nd)	HR	Senior (2)	21 Feb 2020	45:41	F2F

collaborating actors who were involved in Kiabi's strategic renewal. We continued interviewing until information became irrelevant or redundant. Table 1 provides further details on our interviewees.

In recognition of the fact that we were not present at the firm from the start of the path-breaking process, interviewees were also invited to provide historical background on the period 2010–2016. Since interviews were semi-structured, we were able to direct attention to the specific actions and decisions that shaped the change in Kiabi's established action path. The first author invited participants to describe changes in terms of processes, resources, and tools, and made sure that interviewees were as precise as they could on the chronological evolution of change over time. She also asked questions about what Kiabi labelled its "human transformation", that is, how employees were empowered to act upon the firm's strategy. Table 2 details our interview protocol. While we do recognize that the use of semi-structured interviews to cover a (partially) historical process is susceptible to hindsight bias, we believe that this risk is limited because 1) interviewees generally agreed with each other on the process (cf., Golden, 1992), and 2) we performed triangulation with various data sources, which we will list below, which allowed us to reconstruct the early years of Kiabi's path-breaking era.

Second, 88 *documents* were collected, ranging from operational to highly strategic in nature: 27 related to open strategizing, 18 to internal communications, 10 to the supply chain, 13 to marketing, 8 to the collections, 7 to strategy, and 5 to project management· These documents were useful for us to visualize path breaking, especially in the "strategy" or the "open strategizing" categories. For example, an application form for the "Great Place to Work Award" described in further detail how 2010 was a turning point for Kiabi's path development. Furthermore, an HR-created Microsoft Word document described how Kiabi managers facilitated the collective writing of three-year, five-year strategic plans and one-year roadmap to create a path of *integrative collaborative alignment*. In addition, a Microsoft PowerPoint presentation provided by Kiabi's CEO (2015–2019) showed how he promoted "Value Creation Zones", which were temporary, project-focused units that became instrumental in adopting a path of collaboration in the period between 2016 and 2018.

Our third data source consisted of *notes* taken by the first author during 24 company events and meetings. This amounted to 134 h of presence and 148 pages of note transcripts. These events were diverse, ranging from design thinking seminars to all-employee monthly meetings. During these events, the first author acted sometimes as a participant, sometimes as an observer (cf., Van Maanen, 2011). In the first case, she took notes on conversations, discussions and interactions through the lens of her own experience. For example, when attending design thinking seminars, she noted how corporate expectations were changing towards favoring high collaboration of employees for strategy making. In those seminars, store and warehouse staff were invited to give their input on designing the new Kiabi head office and principal store, along with creating in-store innovations. In the second case, she focused on how conversations, speeches, discourse conveyed meaning in regard to Kiabi's transformation. For example, attending monthly meetings in 2018 helped her understand upper management's discourse about how strategic renewal needed to rely not just on collaboration but also on agile methods.

Finally, we examined 163 *press releases* (searched for on the Factiva research tool) and 60 *Google links*. We continued our search for new documents as long as the material was relevant and non-redundant. These types of documents were consulted for process reconstruction purposes, to help us get acquainted with not only what happened before 2010, but also what had been already deployed at Kiabi between 2010 and 2016. For example, the first author learned about the collective creation of the firm's first strategic statements (2010) through secondary sources (articles, Youtube videos). These also instructed her about Kiabi's difficult economic and strategic situation in the early 2010s. Moreover, such information provided a basis for triangulation for the first author's own on-site

Table 2
Interview protocol.

Block 1: Kiabi's transformation (Respondents' point of view)	
Question 1	Can you explain Kiabi's transformation process from the point of view of your position, your function?
Frequent follow-up 1	When did it start? When were you involved?
Question 2	What new projects (or processes) were created in your department?
Question 3	Were projects or processes abandoned?
Question 4	How did it impact your work and your objectives?
Frequent follow-up 1	Did it affect the processes you use?
Frequent follow-up 2	Did it affect the resources/competences you mobilize?
Frequent follow-up 3	Did it affect the people you work with?
Frequent follow-up 4	Did it affect the structure and the roles in your team?
Question 5	What was the outcome of such transformation?
Question 6	What were the most challenging steps?
Question 7	In your opinion, what remains to be done?
Block 2: Kiabi's human transformation	
Question 8	Can you talk to me about Kiabi's human transformation, what started it?
Frequent follow-up 1	How would you describe the human changes experienced at Kiabi over the past few years?
Frequent follow-up 2	What has changed, concretely?
Frequent follow-up 3	What brought, caused, or inspired these changes?
Frequent follow-up 4	How do these changes manifest themselves concretely in your work?
Frequent follow-up 5	What are the consequences of these changes at the company level?
Frequent follow-up 6	What difficulties were encountered? At the firm level? In your work?
Frequent follow-up 7	In your opinion, what remains to be done?

observations. Finally, these documents were useful in connecting with interviewees and building the interviews, most notably because it provided a frame of reference regarding the events shaping Kiabi's path-breaking process.

In our analysis, which was of an explorative, inductive nature, we relied on established methods for theorizing on the basis of process data (Langley, 1999; Jarzabkowski et al., 2017). Data analysis unfolded in five steps: 1) identifying path-breaking interventions over time; 2) writing narratives (thick descriptions); 3) uncovering patterns; 4) identifying temporal brackets; and 5) developing a process flowchart.

In the first step, we explored Kiabi's transformation process, generally looking for moment-by-moment enactments (cf., Jarzabkowski et al., 2017). Evidence from our case highlighted the importance of path-breaking interventions for renewal (that we initially labelled "change events"). We chronologically ordered those interventions over the period 2010–2020, identifying five that particularly impacted Kiabi's strategic direction. The second step involved writing narratives, or thick descriptions (cf., Geertz, 1994; Langley, 1999), to link the crucial events identified in the first step. In this phase, path-breaking interventions became increasingly manifest as a driving force for renewal. In the third step, we observed, while going back to the literature on path dependence and path breaking, how one self-reinforcing mechanism consistently drove Kiabi's strategic transformation: adaptive expectation effects. The commonality between all path-breaking interventions was that they aimed to reach more integrative collaborative alignment between departments. In the fourth step, we employed temporal bracketing (cf., Langley, 1999) to examine how actions of one period led to changes in the context that would affect action in subsequent periods. Four temporal brackets were identified, representing successively how Kiabi 1) tested, 2) clarified, 3) deployed, and 4) refined adaptive expectations towards collaboration. Finally, we built a process flowchart (cf., Miles and Huberman, 1994) to visually depict the unfolding of Kiabi's path breaking. Importantly, this flowchart allowed us to represent relapses towards the old organizational path of disintegrative collaborative alignment, and thus to visualize the dialectic interplay between path breaking and path dependence over time, and to unearth the role of adaptive expectations as a self-reinforcing mechanism at work in this process.

3. Findings

Between 2010 and 2020, Kiabi gradually transitioned from an organizational path of disintegrative alignment, with little collaboration practiced across departmental boundaries and low mutual expectations in that respect, to a path of integrative collaborative alignment, where mutual expectations about the willingness to collaborate had become markedly better. In the process, upper management performed deliberate path-breaking interventions, each involving a *trigger* and *experimentation*, which was followed by firm-wide *implementation*. Triggers to path-breaking interventions referred to the external causes (e.g., competitive pressure) or internal dynamics (e.g., feedback, reflection) that pushed upper management to act on organizational path breaking.

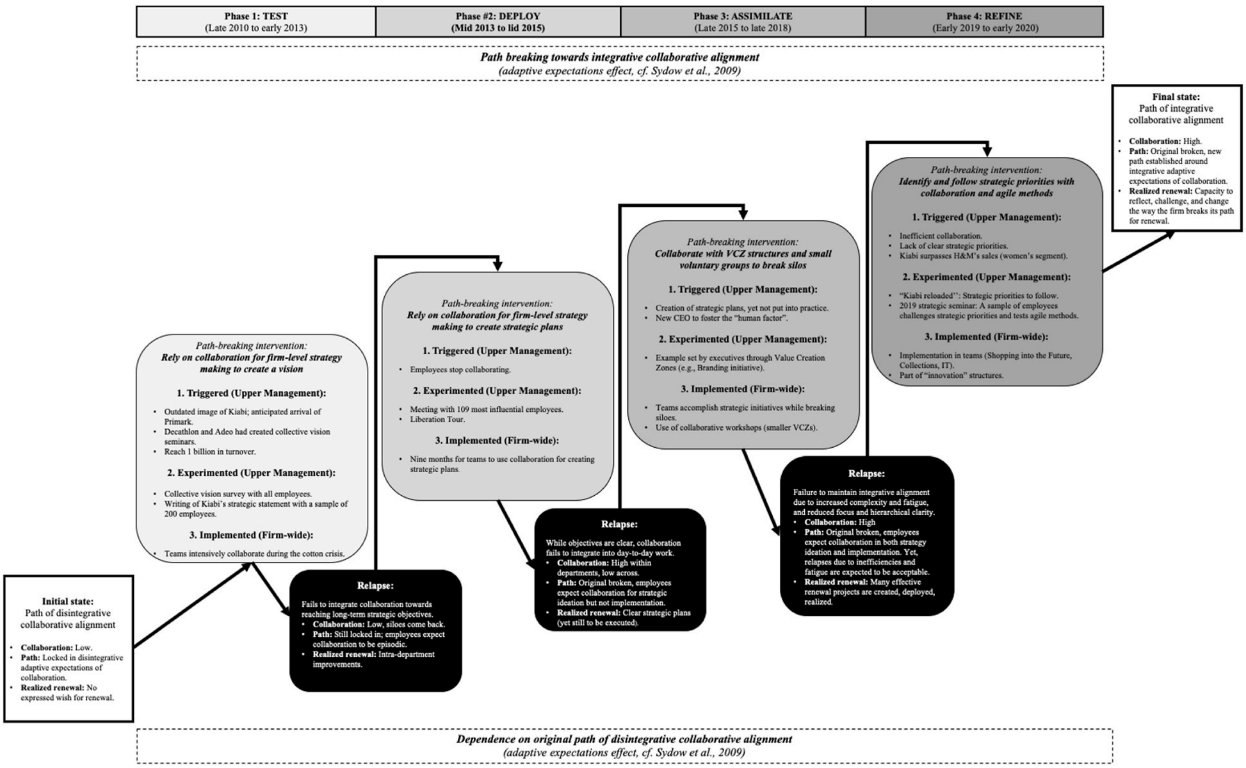

Fig. 2. Process model of path breaking at Kiabi (2010–2020).

Experimentations involved actions conceived by upper management to test path breaking with specific subsets of employees. Implementation pertained to firm-wide actions led by employees to enact path breaking and thus strategic renewal. However, the process also consistently featured relapses towards the original path of disintegrative collaborative alignment (demonstrating the episodic working of organizational path dependence).

Our analysis allowed us to identify four phases in which path breaking occurred. Phase 1, which lasted from late 2010 to early 2013, can be described as *testing*, because it saw the first attempts of path breaking. In phase 2, which took from mid 2013 to mid 2015 and can be labelled *deploying*, path-breaking activities spread throughout the firm. Phase 3, which ran from late 2015 to late 2018, was characterized by *assimilating*, because activities towards more integrative collaborative expectations were starting to take root and give rise to its own lock-in dynamic. Finally, in phase 4, which unfolded between early 2019 and early 2020 and can be denoted as *refining*, path-breaking activities were used to finetune the emerging self-reinforcing expectations around cross-departmental collaboration. Overall, the four phases, depicted in Fig. 2, suggest that strategic renewal involved maneuvering the dialectic between activities towards that renewal (i.e., through path-breaking initiatives) and relapses into strategic inertia (i.e., through the force of path dependence), whereby upper management and the firm at large alternated in driving the process.

3.1. Phase 1 (late 2010 to early 2013): testing

In this phase, Kiabi made its first attempts to break away from its original path of disintegrative collaborative alignment, whereby adaptive expectations regarding cross-departmental collaboration perpetuated organizational silos. Initial path-breaking interventions allowed the firm to test collaboration for firm-wide strategy-making. By late 2010, Kiabi's incoming Chairman and the firm's CEO were exploring how they could reinvigorate Kiabi's strategic position. Negative and positive factors *triggered* their interest in creating a path-breaking intervention. On the one hand, upper management was aware of Kiabi's strong tendency towards silos, as per the Mulliez's strong intrapreneurial culture, which prevented rapid change. On the other hand, it was optimistic about the firm's ability to do things differently, and thought that working on the company's vision might be a suitable solution to change Kiabi's current path:

> We saw the benefits of crafting a vision for our comrades, Decathlon and Adeo [also part of the Mulliez group], and we thought: us too! We have just passed 1 billion euros in figures; it would be good if we started to bring everyone together around a common vision. We had our fundamentals, our values. But the vision of what we wanted to become in 20, 25, 30 years, and our societal role … that was not shared.
>
> —Kiabi's Chairman (2011–2019), Interview #34

The Chairman and CEO thought that stimulating collaboration, which was working well for Decathlon and Adeo, would also allow Kiabi to break away from its highly siloed organization. Upper management then decided to *experiment* with their first path-breaking intervention. The CEO called the Heads of Internal and External Communication, who, in turn, broadly asked managers to create a vision process for Kiabi. There was one rule: everyone in the firm had to be involved in the vision process, from headquarters to stores. The Head of Internal Communication remembered being surprised about the executives' expectations for this initiative:

> I said to [the CEO]: everybody? What do you mean?!! Normally, leaders create a vision and share it with the employees. But that was not what they wanted. It was really about co-constructing the vision.
>
> —Head of Internal Communication, Interview #21

This quote illustrates how stimulating collaboration marked a clear departure from Kiabi's traditional, more top-down ways of organizing. Since collaboration and coordination within and between departments were not natural to Kiabi, the Head of Communication called a consultant specialized in collective intelligence. This consultant suggested that Kiabi first perform a survey of employees' expectations and desires for the firm. Following up on this suggestion, the communication leaders sent an online survey with one central question: *Where do you see Kiabi 10 years from now?* Part of the survey consisted of open-ended questions, such as: *When you enter a Kiabi store, what do you see?* The next step, as suggested by the consultant, was to gather a sample of employees to read through the survey's answers and summarize employees' main expectations. In a big employees' room in December 2010, 300 individuals from all departments and hierarchical layers met for two days to read the survey's printed answers. Their effort resulted into four collectively expressed ambitions about Kiabi's future:

> 1) We are fashion.
>
> 2) We offer a pleasant shopping experience.
>
> 3) We are a step ahead (of competitors).
>
> 4) We are collaborator-actors.
>
> —Provided by HR Happiness Leader, Interview #32

Many employees considered it problematic that Kiabi was perceived as outdated. They wanted to offer something more modern, as Primark did, and take a leading role in the industry. What is more, they wished to be fully involved in Kiabi's transformation. The CEO, Chairman, and executives were content with this first path-breaking intervention. After all, ambition #4 demonstrated that employees were galvanized by the firm's new vision of fostering collaboration to enact Kiabi's transformation. Counting on this potential, executives summarized the firm's vision as "We will be the international multi-channel leader of fashion at low prices," which they emailed to all employees. That ambition, fueled by the promise of collaboration, would serve as new strategic guidelines for the firm's daily operations.

In the following year, due to difficult climatic conditions in India and Pakistan, the price of cotton nearly doubled, which affected the whole fashion retail industry. This circumstance put additional strategic pressure on Kiabi: the firm needed to think short-term, and CEO firmly believed that Kiabi would survive this crisis through collaboration. Against this backdrop, employees activated the *implementation* of the first path-breaking intervention. To do so, they followed the CEO's guidelines—to collaborate so as to keep the firm financially afloat. The CEO remembered being very directive about his expectations, yet also very transparent in his motives. Two years after the start of the crisis, collaboration had finally borne fruit:

> We told them the whole truth and the risks we were running if we did not change. We had to change to avoid the wall that was rising up in front of us. It was a rather directive step. Based on the vision we asked people to take up this challenge and they did it. And at the end of 2012, beginning of 2013, when things were going much better for Kiabi. Thanks to employees' ultra-mobilization.
>
> —Kiabi's CEO (2014–2017)
>
> (Toscane & Cie, 2015: 08:20–09:05)

As an example of effective collaboration, the Head of Raw Material, a former buyer, remembered how her team created new tools and procedures to work collaboratively:

> In 2011, cotton prices soared, it was quite dramatic! And raw material represented 60 % of the cost of the finished product. We were not organized at the time. We each had our quotation files, yet we were not aware of the prices of materials on the market. And then at one point, we centralized our quotation file. We also set up meetings to review our suppliers' occupancy rates, where buyers of the same process started to meet to find ways to increase our negotiating power.
>
> —Raw Material Leader, Interview #43

Such initiatives, especially in the purchasing department, demonstrated to upper management that (intra-department) collaboration was effective at building Kiabi's capacity for renewal.

Yet, much against the CEO's expectations, silos and Kiabi's originally problematic path of disintegrative alignment resurfaced in 2013. Although the cotton crisis and the associated threat to the firm's survival accelerated collaboration, Kiabi's now more stable situation seemed to have brought the firm back onto its initial siloed path:

> At the beginning of 2013, when things were going much better for Kiabi, I had the feeling we were stepping backwards. Everyone was settling back into their comfort zone. Everyone was returning to their silos, walls that had barely been broken down! […] Interdepartmental, inter-service tensions were being recreated; forms of power struggles were finding their place again.
>
> —Kiabi's CEO (2014–2017)
>
> (Toscane & Cie, 2015: 09:05–10:46)

Kiabi indeed showed signs of relapses towards organizational path dependence: it had successfully tested collaboration, but the end of the cotton crisis seemed to have reduced urgency and incited a sense of achievement, which brought back the recourse to trusted behavioral patterns. In effect, employees expected collaboration to be ephemeral. Additionally, the four ambitions formulated in 2010, despite offering a broad sense of strategic direction, remained somewhat vague. If they were to maintain collaborative behaviors over time, employees needed clearer purpose: goals, plans, and concrete ways to break paths.

3.2. Phase 2 (mid 2013 to mid 2015): deploying

By mid-2013, a second path-breaking intervention allowed Kiabi to deploy collaboration at the firm level for strategic renewal. It was *triggered* by a conversation with the consultant who helped with the initial path-breaking intervention in 2010 (Toscane & Cie, 2015). He suggested that the CEO and upper management team should take responsibility for Kiabi's relapse into low interdepartmental collaboration. In response, the CEO reunited the upper management team and suggested the need to intervene. As it did for the first path-breaking intervention, upper management *experimented* with path-breaking with a sample of employees—in this case, as the Value Chain Executive Vice President recalled, with a shock intervention (Toscane Accompagnement, 2018). Upper management convened the 109 most influential managers of the firm, and were unequivocal about their expectations:

> *We got our transformation started in a very simple way. We just told 109 managers, and the number is not trivial ["109" (*cent neuf*) and "new blood" (*sang neuf*) in French are homophonous]: we brought you together today in this room because we are fed up!!! And we need you to help us and participate in this "revolution" that Kiabi needs! We said first: guys, we have to reinvent Kiabi, so we need you to reinvent yourselves first and to reinvent how we organize as well. Second thing, we are going to trust you. Trust is due. So, dare, also with your teams!*
>
> –Value Chain Executive Vice President
>
> (Toscane Accompagnement, 2018: 02:40–07:00)

From there, various managers heeded upper management's call, organizing meetings across France to discuss Kiabi's need to collaborate. As part of the firm's candidacy for the 2014 Best Place to Work Award, HR managers summarized what could be expected from the firm's so-called "Liberation Tour", held between April and June of that year:

> The "liberators" or "first followers" boarded a coach and set out to meet teams throughout the whole of France (2,000 participants in 35 towns) to share this wake-up call and fuel people's energy on the need to work more closely together, do things differently and faster, and to be more trusting
>
> —Kiabi's liberation, p. 4

Nevertheless, the liberation tour failed to integrate collaboration towards reaching long-lasting strategic objectives. Teams were lacking purpose: "Collaboration, yes, but what for?" (Archambault and Hennon, 2021). Kiabi HR's Happiness Leader (Director level) remembered realizing that the answer to that question was involving employees in strategy-making. That would make them change their behavior in the long run. She explained how the upper management committee now expected teams to deliver their own action plans that would contribute to the firm's overarching vision:

> We realized that what was created in the first [2010] vision workshop was still too far from the business unit's realities. For example, creating a pleasant shopping experience, how is it linked to the HR strategy? We all had the same basis, but every team needed to write their own personal contribution.
>
> —Happiness Leader, HR Department, Interview #32

With the need for further integration in mind, the Happiness Leader pursued the *implementation* of this second path-breaking intervention, establishing a clear procedure to deploy the use of collaboration for strategic purposes at the firm level. A broadly shared Microsoft PowerPoint document entitled "Vision Process Procedure Kiabi 2015" clarified what was expected from departments in different time periods: First, business units and departments would have nine months to write their five-year, three-year and one-year strategic plans in collaboration from October 2014 to May 2015. Those plans would be presented to the upper management committee and a representative of each department by July 2015. Then, an encompassing vision document (vision, mission, and objectives, including all business units and departments' strategic plans) would be sent to all employees as new guiding principles.

Here, collaboration was core to creating new strategic plans, since teams had to do it together. Path breaking started to consolidate, with integrative collaborative alignment emerging as the new norm. Collaboratively discussing pressing issues forced teams to ideate concrete solutions to unresolved problems that hampered strategic renewal. For example, the projects team launched what they called the LSD project, "Link Supply and Demand". It identified in its strategic plans how budgets and objectives for country business units (the ones selling, the demand) and collections departments (e.g., the ones providing, the supply) were not aligned. Nevertheless, moving from ideating to executing those solutions proved to be arduous. An LSD project manager remembered how achieving collaboration was still difficult, because structural divides had to be bridged:

> There was a real barrier that existed between these two entities [supply and demand]. We did not talk to each other enough. We decided to break down the barriers that existed. LSD came from there: it was about breaking down silos. Except that this is all good in theory. But it's not because we say it that barriers will automatically collapse, that we'll go see our colleagues and say it's cool, we're best friends, and we'll work together. In real life, it's still more complicated, especially since they continue to work like this, and them, like that.
>
> —Leader, Projects team, Interview #14

As this example shows, Kiabi was once again relapsing into its original path of disintegrative collaboration alignment, in particular across department boundaries. While collaboration proved effective for the ideation of strategic plans, it failed to solve those problems in practice. In fact, employees expected collaboration to be meant strictly for strategic ideation, but not for strategic implementation. This relapse, however, was not as deep as the first relapse described in phase 1. Employees wanted to collaborate to execute strategic plans, but did not know how to move from doing it for ideation to executing those ideas in practice. The ideation phase was about getting collective agreements on problems and finding high-level solutions to address them. Yet, concretely resolving those problems required deeper collaboration and the further breaking of silos. Letting go of power, listening to each other's concerns, and changing processes and procedures were still challenges for Kiabi. Thus, at this stage, collaboration for path breaking was still predominantly oriented towards ad hoc, high-level strategy making; it was not integrated into employees' day-to-day work.

3.3. Phase 3 (late 2015 to late 2018): assimilating

In late 2015, Kiabi's Chairman hired a new CEO, which gave rise to a third path-breaking intervention that allowed the firm to assimilate collaboration for path breaking in day-to-day practice. Given the importance of Kiabi's path-breaking efforts relying on collaboration, the Chairman expected to have someone strong on what he described as the "human factor". In retrospect, he remembered this new CEO's unique approach:

> I needed a guy who was excellent on involving people. He has all the qualities to be a particular kind of CEO. I think he has an atypical profile and yes, he radicalized and accelerated the company's ability to transform. He didn't put any pressure on the costs, he didn't put any pressure on the numbers … he put pressure on the human factor, and on the fact that we needed to do things differently.

—Chairman (2010–2019), Interview #34

The CEO's main mission would now be to help employees move from collaboratively ideating strategic plans to relying on collaboration for day-to-day work. He therefore started thinking about a third path-breaking intervention. This intervention was *triggered*, according to the CEO, by his recognition that Kiabi did not have the right organizational structures to escape its siloed path:

> We had common goals. We had a well-being environment. And people got motion, it was truly incredible! Yet I realized that our siloed organizations were holding us back and blocking us. I said to myself. No, enough, that's it. We're going to open everything up. Free up spaces of freedom.
>
> —CEO (2015–2019), Interview #29

The CEO thought that existing structures constrained work and that employees lacked the freedom to enact path breaking. To that aim, by mid-2015, he convened all Kiabi's Headquarter employees and showed them an image with four circles that he called Value Creation Zones (VCZs). Those VCZs represented "spaces of freedom" or communities of employees who could voluntarily contribute, outside of their main missions, to Kiabi's four newly established strategic priorities. Upper management had identified international development, branding, innovation, and a happy culture as the firm's central concerns for renewal. The CEO summarized what he expected from VCZs as such:

> Each VCZ were launched to call for volunteers who wanted to put their talents to use and develop the stakes of the VCZ. I, an employee, could give 10–50 % of my time to one stake of the company and work hand in hand with other members of my community.
>
> —CEO (2015–2019)
>
> (Archambault and Hennon, 2021: 119)

Employees were puzzled by this new mode of organizing: How would they practically combine doing their jobs and getting involved in these strategic initiatives? Once again, upper management decided to *experiment* with this third path-breaking intervention. The CEO suggested that Executive Vice Presidents (EVPs) should set an example of how VCZ should work. For example, the Marketing EVP started organizing "VCZ Brand" meetings in 2016 with focused groups of volunteers in France, Italy, Spain, and Russia to discuss how the Kiabi brand should move away from its outdated image. Meetings would use collaborative practices, with brainstorming sessions and the collective selection of the best ideas. Over the course of six months, the EVPs met with a sample of 600 employees and had good material to revamp Kiabi's brand, which was entirely changed by 2017.

Initiatives such as these paved the way for employees to rely on collaboration to enact path breaking and reach the strategic objectives set in 2015. It was now up to the employees to *implement* this third path-breaking intervention. For example, a market study manager, who used to work mostly alone, decided to stop producing reports and to start working collaboratively instead. Autonomously deciding to replicate Kiabi's VCZ structure, she gathered groups of volunteers to determine, for example, how they could improve Kiabi's offering. On this basis, employees started to voice concern and even try on apparel to concretely identify problems and solutions to make the offering more appealing. Various interviews (e.g., #1, #16, #38, #39) suggest that those recommendations were quickly acted on by the Collections department. Furthermore, the Market Studies Leader remembered how collaboration radically changed market research at Kiabi, thus proving for collaboration's now inscribed patterns:

> We do VCZs at a lower level … they are small communities. You are no longer the only decision-makers on your subject. It is always about working in collaboration. I find that the big difference, and what has changed at Kiabi since the time I arrived, is that I have my market studies job, but I can do it with collaboration.
>
> —Market Studies Leader, Interview #12

In a similar fashion, throughout 2016, 2017, and 2018, many important projects were implemented through collaboration for Kiabi's strategic renewal, as demonstrated by our interviews, documents and field observations. First, Kiabi changed its brand identity with a new tagline, "Happiness looks good on you," and new visuals. Second, it revamped its collections with a new fashion identity, using season-specific themes and colors. Third, it streamlined its supply chain processes, choosing fewer suppliers to work with. Finally, Kiabi opened stores in new countries such as Belgium and Brazil. An important milestone was reached in early 2018, when Kiabi beat H&M's sales in France in the women's segment.

Nevertheless, while Kiabi's strategic renewal process was effective, the firm's path-breaking process started to show deficiencies. Employees came to discover that collaboration had its limits, which made it more difficult for Kiabi to maintain its path of integrative collaborative alignment. Several factors caused another relapse towards path dependence. First, according to the Head of Project Management, collaboration was time-consuming:

> When you listen to everyone, you start doing something, but there is someone who wasn't in the loop in the first place who says, "No, that's not okay, you shouldn't do [your project] like that, certain things are missing." He might be right, so you readjust, etc. So, the price to pay, what we have seen retroactively: listening to people and getting them to participate: it takes a long time.
>
> —Head of Project Management, Interview #46

Furthermore, employees were getting irritated that collaboration, at least as implemented at Kiabi, could not deliver fast results. Moreover, many new projects kept emerging at the firm, causing a general feeling of exhaustion, thus inducing inertia. The assistant to the CEO remembers feeling being stuck:

> We realized that we had too many projects; the teams were burned-out. People were saying, “We can’t do it anymore because we have too many projects,” we had people who were on four or five projects simultaneously, which had to be deployed at the same time, and people said, “We spend our lives in meetings, explaining things, and things are not moving forward.”
>
> —Executive Assistant to the CEO, Interview #47

Finally, the first author’s field notes reveal that employees voiced a strong need for prioritization. As strategic objectives were reached, and new projects emerged, employees were losing sight of what was strategically important. Since collaboration was the new norm, nobody seemed to want to take the lead on decision-making anymore.

As collaboration was losing some of its appeal, employees relapsed into their habits, leading them back towards disintegrative collaborative alignment. For example, in October of 2018, a former project manager took on a newly created role as a Leader Organization Value Chain for the LSD project (mentioned in phase 2). This project was previously undertaken by project managers and overseen by the EVP Value Chain. Yet, the project needed to be more closely supervised to ensure smoother collaboration. As it was, it was energy consuming due to conflict and power struggles. In particular, when working on a new software called Merchandise Assortment Planning, country-specific business units wanted the software to propose a broad range of products and a high level of customization for each country or region, whereas the Head Office wanted to limit Kiabi’s offering to a more strict and standardized range of products. Agreement was hard to achieve between the Collections department and country-specific business units. The Leader Organization Value Chain remembered that his main objective taking on his new role would be to smother resurfacing siloed thinking:

> My need in relation to these teams is to stop thinking in silos, to adopt a more transversal approach, to have a clear vision of the projects that contributes to improving the value chain at Kiabi, and to keep things simple and fun.
>
> —Leader, Organization Value Chain Interview #42

To summarize, Kiabi’s original path of disintegrative collaboration alignment, in particular across department boundaries, was effectively broken in this third phase. Intensifying collaboration and new strategic initiatives showed the cumulative impact of previous path-breaking interventions. Strategic renewal became effective, with projects positively impacting Kiabi’s competitive position in its markets. Nevertheless, collaboration once again started to show limits, which made it hard to maintain a path of integrative collaborative alignment. There was a relapse towards path dependence, as employees showed a lack of alignment and agility. Effectively, employees expected relapses due to inefficiencies and fatigue to be acceptable. This relapse was nonetheless weaker than the two previous ones. We could observe how progress was retained from phases 1 and 2. Employees experienced fatigue having to defend their ideas in a collaborative setting, but even if there was a degree of nostalgia for the siloed structure, they continued collaborating.

3.4. Phase 4 (early 2019 to early 2020): refining

Following the aforementioned negative consequences of collaboration, Kiabi’s fourth path-breaking intervention was *triggered* by the wish to keep its renewal and path-breaking process going. From a competitive standpoint, things were going well for Kiabi: “It is when it is nice outside that it is time to fix the roof,” said the CEO to the Leader “Shopping into the Future” (Interview #31). Still, upper management took responsibility for streamlining the firm’s strategic priorities and refining collaboration, fixing its inherent problems. To that aim, in this final path-breaking intervention, Kiabi incorporated agile methods, which is an approach to innovation based on rapidly succeeding episodes of experimentation that supports rapid learning in fast-moving environments (Rigby et al., 2016). This move marked the definitive shift in adaptive expectations regarding cross-departmental collaboration towards a path of integrative alignment.

In December 2018, upper management called an all-employee meeting called “Kiabi Reloaded”. This *experiment* was meant to create a wake-up call, similar to the meeting held with the 109 most influential managers in 2013. Upper management wanted to clarify new strategic priorities, since collaboration led to an increase of strategic projects, which required prioritization. As part of this experiment, upper management presented 20 strategic priorities among an initial list of 70 and told the employees to refocus their attention on those priorities only. Moreover, they informed employees that from now on, Kiabi needed to be more agile. Indeed, upper management had travelled to Scandinavia to visit start-ups, and had discovered the benefits of agility in terms of user-centeredness, fast prototyping, and fast delivery.

The experiment was continued three months later, in early March, 1991, with what was called “Kiabi’s 2019 Strategic Seminar”. Upper management gathered a representative sample of 50 employees from all departments and countries and asked to challenge its strategic priorities. Employees were stimulated to collaborate in doing so, as they had done for several years now. The first author attended this seminar and saw how, in small groups, employees were asked to raise points of attention, potential dangers, or conditions for those priorities to be feasible.

In effect, the introduction of agile methods next to collaboration was a way for upper management to refine path breaking, because it promoted fast prototyping and delivery, which were both believed to remedy the previously arisen limitations to collaboration. To help employees adopt agile methods, upper management hired specialized external consultants and made employees test agile “roles” in a workshop. To illustrate, the first author, who participated in the activity, played the “Scrum Master”, facilitating time-constrained product development cycles (“sprints”) while crafting a new handbag for Kiabi. Next, to ensure more thorough appropriation, upper management organized training sessions on agile methods. During the *implementation* of this fourth path-breaking intervention, teams started using agile methods in their daily work. For example, as part of a new strategic project called "Shopping into the Future" that was presented during "Kiabi Reloaded", teams took only five days to create eight "big bets" that promoted new forms of retail, such as second-hand corners in Kiabi stores. Furthermore, the Collections and IT teams created specific innovative structures—the "Trendslab" and the "Digital Factory"—to stimulate product design. Overall, initiatives such as these suggest that employees were getting more autonomous in building collaborative temporary project units.

By late 2019, Kiabi had fully entered a path of integrative alignment, where collaboration across departments, boosted by agile methods, was commonly expected. According to the Head of Internal Communication, agile methods, coupled with now widely adopted collaborative behaviors, gave employees the common objectives they needed to effectively work together:

> Agile methods appropriated by [Kiabi's employees], it is two things: We were going to be more efficient, [and] it is the fact of putting our clients back at the heart of the process. Because it also allows you to speak with all the interlocutors in a fluid and efficient way. For the Collections department, it allowed the stylists, the Trendslabs, the people who do product development, up to the market managers, to speak to each other more easily. And when you put the client at the heart, you're re-establishing a common objective.
>
> —Head of Internal Communication, Interview #48

3.5. *Epilogue*

Over the period of a decade, Kiabi broke its original path, which was driven by adaptive expectations around the absence of cross-departmental collaboration—that is, disintegrative collaborative alignment. Kiabi did so by gradually putting itself onto a path characterized by adaptive expectation effects around the presence of cross-departmental relations—that is, integrative collaborative alignment. This iterative process featured two types of dialectics, which are summarized in Table 3. First, instances of strategic renewal, manifest in the form of path-breaking interventions aimed at instilling integrative collaborative alignment throughout the organization, were alternated temporarily by relapses towards the firm's original path of disintegrative collaborative alignment. Initial tests with cross-departmental collaboration for a new strategic vision culminated in a lacking sense of urgency, which marked a step backwards toward organizational silos. This relapse inspired the firm-level deployment of cross-departmental collaboration for strategic planning, which eventually lost momentum due to the fact that organization-structural divides formed a mental barrier to collaboration. In response, structural space was created in the form of VCZs to further push collaborative strategy execution. However, in the VCZ, employees started to experience the time- and energy-consuming nature of cross-departmental collaboration, which brought back nostalgic feelings for the original siloed structure. Those feelings were finally smothered with the introduction of agile methods, which proved the last missing ingredient for employees to autonomously and dynamically collaborate across departments for the formulation and execution of strategy.

Second, we observed a dialectical tension between upper management and Kiabi's broader employee population through the recurring sequences of the triggering of, experimenting with, and implementing of path-breaking interventions. While upper management was most prominently involved when path-breaking intervention was triggered and experimented with, Kiabi at large came into play when upper management's experiments with collaborative practices were rolled out. While the rollouts moved the intervention from the firm's upper to the lower hierarchical levels, the ensuing relapses towards the firm's original path of disintegrative collaborative alignment pushed the path-breaking process back to upper management, since they sparked strategic reflection and a sense of responsibility among top executives. In phase 1, upper management saw the need for a new, broadly shared corporate vision, which all employees were invited to contribute to. When that vision lost momentum, it deepened its commitment to collaboration, adding the execution dimension in phase 2. When firm-wide collaborative strategy execution stalled due to lingering structural divides, changes were made to that structure, which led to the creation of the VCZs, thus ushering in phase 3. In that phase, practice highlighted the time and energy intensiveness of complex collaboration, which finally prompted upper management to introduce the element of agile methods in phase 4. When implemented by the various VCZs, these methods proved the key to anchoring integrative collaborative alignment among the ranks of Kiabi.

Across the working of both dialectics, both path breaking and path dependence involved self-reinforcing mechanisms, which became manifest in the way adaptive expectations evolved (cf. Sydow et al., 2009). On the one hand, each path-breaking intervention marked progress towards integrative collaborative alignment that relapses could not completely undo, and subsequent path-breaking events could build on what had been retained in terms of the growing disposition towards collaboration across Kiabi. On the other hand, every relapse featured a (diminishing, due to path breaking, but still self-reinforcing) tendency towards organizational silos that could (eventually) have led to a full relapse into disintegrative collaborative alignment, had upper management not intervened with successive path-breaking interventions. At the end of phase 1, the expectation of intra-firm collaboration had been established. Yet, collaboration was expected to be ephemeral and there was no strong cross-departmental orientation. When phase 2 ended, the expectation of interdepartmental collaboration was more entrenched around the firm, but it did not extend to day-to-day practice, so the new strategic focus could still get bogged down in siloed implementation. Subsequently, the closing of phase 3 saw the broad practice of collaboration, but fatigue and inefficiencies spawning from collaboration were still deemed acceptable. Potentially, this forgivingness may have culminated into a loss of momentum, had upper management not introduced agile methods as the fourth and final path-breaking intervention.

In sum, Kiabi's path-breaking process, characterized by these two dialectics, brought about strategic renewal. Table 4 provides a "before and after" of the firm's collaborative shift. As outlined above, path breaking involved a gradual, iterative change to and

Table 3
Dialectics between path breaking/path dependence and upper management/firm at large.

	Path-breaking towards integrative collaborative alignment			Relapses into disintegrative collaborative alignment (original path dependence)		
	Upper management interventions	*Firm-wide implementation*	*Adaptive expectations*	*Implementation gap*	*Adaptive expectations*	*Upper management reflection and action*
Phase 1: TEST	Tests of collaboration to create a firm-level vision.	Execution of collaboration during cotton price crisis.	Intra-departmental collaboration.	No long-term strategic objectives; lack of urgency, sense of achievement.	Collaboration is temporary.	Observation of the need to address the resurfacing path of siloed work.
Phase 2: DEPLOY	Use of collaboration for firm-level strategy-making to create strategic plans.	Employees autonomously attempt strategy execution.	Interdepartmental collaboration for strategic purposes.	Extant structures constrain employees in collaboratively moving from strategic planning to execution.	Intradepartmental collaboration concerns strategy, not daily implementation.	Change of CEO, reflection on the need to provide the freedom to execute strategy through collaboration.
Phase 3: ASSIMI-LATE	Creation of Value Creation Zones to allow employees to break silos in strategy execution.	Strategic initiatives are taken in temporary project units while silos are being broken.	Interdepartmental collaboration on strategic and operational projects.	Collaboration fatigue; continued collaboration despite nostalgia for siloed structure.	Relapses due to fatigue and inefficiencies are acceptable.	Reflection on the need to streamline strategic priorities and fix collaboration's inherent problems.
Phase 4: REFINE	Introduction of agile methods to pursue select strategic priorities meant to provide clear guidance.	Agile methods and collaboration are combined; autonomous creation of (temporary) project units.	Fully realized integrative collaborative alignment.	N/A	N/A	N/A

recurrent reinforcement of the adaptive expectations (cf., Sydow et al., 2009, 2020) that governed the firm's strategic range from disintegrative to integrative collaborative alignment. This break did not result in a wholly new strategy, but a repositioning within the same overall low-cost position, supported by a suitable organizational structure and culture. This outcome was intentional (i.e., conform the agentic principle of path breaking), because our interviews suggest that executives saw the need to *update* (rather than change) the firm's strategic position around *existing* core values. Yet, due to the countervailing self-reinforcing mechanisms involved, the process had an emerging component, whereby upper management had to repeatedly address sequential implementation gaps. Eventually, the new strategic focus opened the organizational structure rendering the firm more agile in dealing with external factors, such as economic recessions, price fluctuations, competitive dynamics, and the shifting fashion trends of the 2010s. In so doing, Kiabi reaped both the organizational and financial benefits from breaking its original path: while it won several awards, showcasing the progress it had made as an employer, it doubled its profits in the period from 2012, when the effects of the financial crisis started to wane, to 2020, while revenues stably hovered around €1.1 billion across this period.

4. Discussion

Although strategic renewal has often and also recently attracted scholarly attention for its effect on long-term organizational performance and survival (Perini et al., 2024), research on its most difficult instances, namely those that involve escaping counter-productive locked-in action paths, remains scant (Schmitt et al., 2018). Since most recent literature adheres to a binary opposition of path breaking and path dependence with respect to strategic renewal and inertia (e.g., De Groote and Kammerlander, 2023; Löfsten et al., 2024; Zientara and Müller-Seitz, 2024), the way(s) in which managers might maneuver self-reinforcing processes to achieve strategic renewal remains underexplored (Perini et al., 2024).

In our study, we have endeavored to look broadly at the (enabling and constraining) effects of self-reinforcing mechanisms on Kiabi's ability to effect strategic change, focusing on adaptive expectations in particular. Our principal finding is the existence of dialectical relationships between 1) path-breaking interventions (towards integrative collaborative alignment) and relapses into organizational path dependence (disintegrative collaborative alignment), both of which involved the self-reinforcing mechanism of adaptive expectation effects; and 2) upper management decisions/actions and firm-wide implementation. Both dialectics are marked by several successive iterations that gradually, and in conjunction with each other, gave rise to strategic renewal even under the adverse circumstances of organizational path dependence. This more nuanced view of strategic renewal, in which path breaking and path dependence flow into each other as part of one and the same strategic transformation process, is amenable to three theoretical contributions to the literature on strategic renewal.

First, we provide more granularity on the propulsive role that organizational path dependence can play in strategic renewal projects, articulating what drives its dialectic with path breaking. As demonstrated by Table 3, the relapses into path dependence that followed path-breaking interventions, which became manifest to upper management as implementation gaps in the promotion of interdepartmental collaboration, consistently sparked strategic reflection, and, eventually, further path-breaking interventions, until the new path was fully instilled. Thus, while initially impacting path breaking as "roadblocks", relapses into path dependence can subsequently serve as "road signs" that managers can use to identify problem areas that can, in turn, guide their way towards path-breaking organizational change. In this fashion, lingering (though diminishing) path-dependent tendencies can form an integral part of strategic renewal. The dialectic's procession critically hinges on top-level managerial agency, through which organizational problems are identified and addressed as they emerged. In this light, it makes intuitive sense that path breaking is not a one-off event. Rather, path breaking requires a series of corrective interventions, because managers, despite their agency, are boundedly rational, and do not always have full oversight as to how a strategic repositioning should be implemented (Garud and Karnøe, 2003; Giddens, 1984). The emphasis on managerial agency (which does not necessarily contradict the constraining and enabling role of structure) might also have broader relevance to the study of strategic renewal, because if managers can "coopt" self-reinforcing inertial forces in the promotion of strategic renewal, they will likely also be able to do so with relapses that do not (immediately) have this tendency.

Second, by mapping the dialectic between upper management and the broader firm, we both confirm and extend the notion of managerial agency in the breaking of organizational paths (Fortwengel and Keller, 2020). Agentic perspectives on organizational path dependence typically attribute the ability to break paths to the firm's upper echelon (Petermann et al., 2019; Sydow et al., 2020). Thereby, even studies that highlight intra-firm collaboration as a basis for path breaking tend to treat organizations as a unified whole (Perini et al., 2024; Su et al., 2023), overlooking the way(s) in which the broader organizational hierarchy may guide or channel that collaboration. Our analysis demonstrates that, across several iterations, upper management provided the basis for breaking organizational paths (though triggers and experimentation), while employees—as to be expected—performed the broader implementation. Hence, breaking an organizational path appears to necessarily mobilize most, if not all, of the firm's hierarchical layers. Moreover, this patterned interplay between upper management and other hierarchical layers provides a specification as to how strategic paths can be broken from within. On that basis, it nuances functional or fit-based models of adaptation, which connect strategic renewal primarily to exogenous shocks, and remain dominant in the study of strategic renewal (e.g., Karim and Mitchell, 2000; Pratap and Saha, 2018).

Paradoxically, because of the self-reinforcing mechanisms it involves, the latter dialectic also supports a third contribution, as it attenuates the dominant assumption of managerial agency in the literature on open strategy (cf., Hautz et al., 2017). In its search for a new strategic focus, Kiabi resorted to the practice of open strategy. If realizing firm-wide collaboration can be considered a move toward strategic openness, relapses towards siloed thinking, which call for more top-down decision-making, represent steps towards strategic closure. The interplay between upper management and Kiabi at large sheds alternative light on the relationship between the "opening" and "closing" of strategy. Whereas the transition between the two is commonly seen as a function of deliberate managerial action (Dobusch et al., 2019; Splitter et al., 2023), for example through such notions as "punctuated closure" (Diriker et al., 2023), our

Table 4
Comparison of Kiabi's inertial and renewal periods.2010–2019).

	Inertial period (before 2010)	Renewal period (after 2010)
Self-reinforcement	Adaptive expectation effect through *disintegrative collaborative alignment*: Silos due to expectation that collaboration won't be taken up by other departments.	Adaptive expectation effects through *integrative collaborative alignment*: Silos are broken and cross-departmental collaboration becomes a common practice.
Strategic focus	*Low-cost, "basic" apparel for the whole family*: Kiabi applies low-cost retail models from the broader Mulliez Group to the apparel industry.	*Fashionable, low-cost apparel for the whole family*, based on collaborative, agile strategic planning and execution.
Structure	*Classic hierarchical, multidivisional structure* with low synergies. *Example*: Purchasing, Logistics and Warehouses divisions are managed in silos.	*Hierarchical, yet more open*: Employees collaboratively contribute to various strategic projects called Value Creation Zones (VCZs), which focus on international development, innovation and transformation, branding, and "happy culture". *Example*: Purchasing, logistics and warehouse departments regroup into one 'Supply Chain' encompassing department.
External conditions	Kiabi is *vulnerable* to such external factors as economic recessions, the rise of new competitors, changing markets and technologies, and increases in raw material prices.	Integrative collaborative alignment has tightened Kiabi's connection with its market and rendered it more *agile* in the face of external dynamics.
Performance	Revenues reach €1 billion in 2010.	With revenues hovering around €1.1 billion, profitability doubles from €24 million in 2012 to €54 million. Kiabi is a "Great Place to Work" from 2014 to 2018.

study demonstrates that it can involve self-reinforcing mechanisms through both path breaking (self-reinforcing integrative collaborative alignment) and path dependence (self-reinforcing disintegrative collaborative alignment), which, by definition, limit the scope for managerial action in that process. The image of open strategy being practiced in a context of potentially constraining structures extends Holstein and Rantakari (2023) suggestion that the move between strategic openness and closure may involve a degree of unintentionality, even if Kiabi's moves between open and closed strategy were circumscribed by deliberate path-breaking interventions. Indeed, these interventions (acting on adaptive expectations) constitute a way in which managers can (at least to some extent) maneuver these structures in the pursuit of open strategy and/or strategic renewal.

Our findings also have practical implications. First and foremost, they suggest that managers engaged in breaking organizational paths should not think about strategic inertia and strategic renewal in strictly binary terms, whereby either one or the other prevails. By extension, (relapses into) path dependence should not be seen as categorically limiting or threatening. Our study demonstrates that the aftereffects of remerging path dependence can, in effect, expedite the path-breaking process. Whenever a relapse into old behavioral patterns occurs, it is not necessarily a sign that path breaking is definitively failing and should therefore be abandoned. On the contrary, it may indicate that follow-up interventions are called for. Second, our research demonstrates that breaking paths may requires the input of all layers of the organization. Upper echelons may have the overarching vision and can initiate path-breaking interventions, but the breaking of an organizational path towards strategic renewal can only materialize through organization-wide implementation. Our study thus suggests that the upper echelon should not only focus on the content dimension of path-breaking interventions (i.e., what strategic direction to take), but also on the process dimension (i.e., how can path breaking be achieved). To this aim, managers could utilize open strategy processes (cf., Hautz et al., 2017), which provide ways to manage cross-hierarchical and interdepartmental coordination and the complexities that it may involve.

5. Future research and concluding remarks

Our contributions also give rise to at least two avenues for future research. First and foremost, there might be variations to the dialectics that we observed based on organizational and environmental factors, explorations of which may further the discussion on the interplay between path breaking and path dependence (e.g., Bohnsack et al., 2021; Sminia et al., 2024). In the case of Kiabi, the alternation between path-breaking initiatives towards cross-departmental collaboration and relapses into the path dependence of siloed thinking revolved around a constant type of lock-in mechanism: adaptive expectations effects. Other types of adaptive expectations are conceivable, such as those around leadership and self-regulation (Sosik et al., 2002). Beyond adaptive expectations, alternative forms of lock-in mechanisms, such as complementarity, learning, and coordination effects (Sydow et al., 2009, 2020), may play a role. Future studies could explore whether these self-reinforcing mechanisms are similarly amenable to path-breaking interventions, whether path breaking away from one type of lock-in mechanism can eventually trigger another type of lock-in mechanism, and if yes, under what conditions. Relatedly, if there are variations of the dialectics between path breaking and path dependence, a natural follow-up question would be how they affect organizational outcomes. At Kiabi, the breaking of the organizational path made the firm gradually more agile in response to the sequential relapses, and heralded a period of increased profitability. Yet, different outcomes—positive and negative—are possible, and those could be connected to yet unobserved dimensions of the alternation between path breaking and path dependence.

In a similar vein, there might be variations of the dialectics we observed between Kiabi's upper management and the organization as a whole during the roll-out of path-breaking initiatives. Across the iterations of path breaking and path dependence that we mapped, we observed a recurring pattern of initiatives towards path breaking being triggered and experimented with at the upper management level before getting implemented at lower levels of the organizational hierarchy. In turn, implementation gave rise to relapses into path-dependent behavior and/or thinking that ultimately triggered further path breaking. That sequence may be specific to contextual factors, such as Kiabi's size (which accommodated several layers of management), culture (which became increasingly oriented towards open strategy), and industry (whose dynamism requires a degree of adaptability). Examining firms and other types of organization of varying industries, sizes, and cultures may therefore advance understanding of the organizational dynamics that undergird the execution of path-breaking interventions, and extend the evolving literature that sets out to "unpack" path breaking and path dependence in and among organizations (e.g., Joseph and Sengul, 2025; Perchard and MacKenzie, 2021). Ultimately, this line of enquiry could provide insights into the complex of factors that favor or inhibit path breaking, its (non)linearity and temporal dimensions, and its link with competitiveness.

Second, our four stages of the path-breaking process inspire broader questions about the way managerial agency and irreversibility—the two core ingredients of path breaking and path dependence, respectively—relate to each other, and thus speaks to the thriving discussion on (the limits of) managerial agency in strategy-making (e.g., Poulis et al., 2021; Simsek et al., 2022). The first three phases—testing, deploying, and assimilating—are delineated by "inflection points" beyond which the agency that drives path breaking is (episodically) overtaken by the irreversibility of the original path. At Kiabi, the barriers that caused path-breaking initiatives to lose momentum included a lacking sense of urgency, structural hurdles, and fatigue, and thus ranged from cognitive to practical to psychological. As such, they seem to neatly correspond to the cycle of rational idea formulation and implementation. Yet, it remains unclear whether they are innate to path breaking, and thus unavoidable, or result from some organizational dynamic external to the path-breaking project. Further conceptualization of these barriers could therefore shed more light on the degree and kind of agency that organizational actors enjoy when performing path-breaking interventions. Furthermore, our analysis suggests that the relapses become milder as path-breaking progresses, to the point where the new organizational path becomes locked in. The diminishing strength of the relapses begs the question which (structural) conditions need to be met for path-breaking to succeed. Closer examination of the relapses could reveal factors and circumstances that determine which force—path breaking or path dependence—prevails, and whether the relapses always diminish in strength as path breaking progresses.

However, despite its contributions and implications, our analysis is subject to limitations and scope conditions. First, path breaking at Kiabi is an ongoing process, so we may not have captured the end of the process—or the full extent of path breaking's self-reinforcing nature—by the time we wrapped up data collection (due to Covid-19). Even if our study demonstrates several iterations of the dialectics between the break of a path towards integrative collaborative alignment and relapses into disintegrative collaborative alignment, there might have been further path-breaking interventions or relapses into path dependence. Second, we faced an observation problem regarding the self-reinforcing nature of Kiabi's path dependent relapses. Although we were able to connect implementation gaps to adaptive expectations of interdepartmental collaboration, which are commonly theorized as self-reinforcing (Sydow et al., 2009, 2020), relapses were consistently addressed by management before all path-breaking momentum was lost. Finally, there are scope conditions to our findings. Most notably, Kiabi is known for its now open strategy (cf., Hautz et al., 2017) and fluid structures, which may be particularly conducive to the interplay between hierarchical levels on the one hand, and the iterations between path breaking and path dependence on the other. The observed dialectics may be less likely in organizations governed by a stronger hierarchy, where managerial agency is more centralized and decision-making tends to flow top-down, with relatively little input from the lower levels of management.

Nonetheless, even in light of the aforementioned limitations, there is ample evidence for our core findings regarding the existence of dialectics between path breaking and path dependence within organizations. Thinking beyond the traditional binary opposition between inertia and renewal and path dependence and path breaking, as well as the duality of stability and change (Farjoun, 2010), could help both academics and practitioners broaden their perspective on organizational evolution, and become more aware of the nuances that it involves. In so doing, they may become better equipped to grasp and/or address the complexity of interorganizational competition and thus to pursue their long-term mission of survival and prosperity.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Catherine Archambault Janvier: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Wim Van Lent:** Writing – review & editing, Visualization, Methodology, Conceptualization. **Jörg Sydow:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Conceptualization.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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